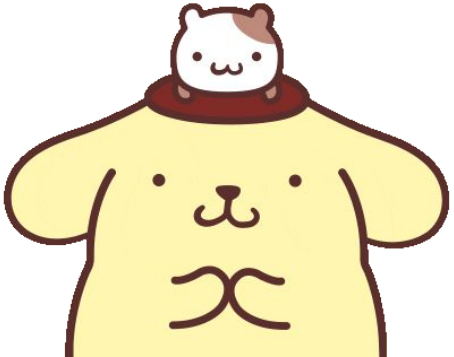
The Myths & Insights of your (early) tech career

by: TJ Klint



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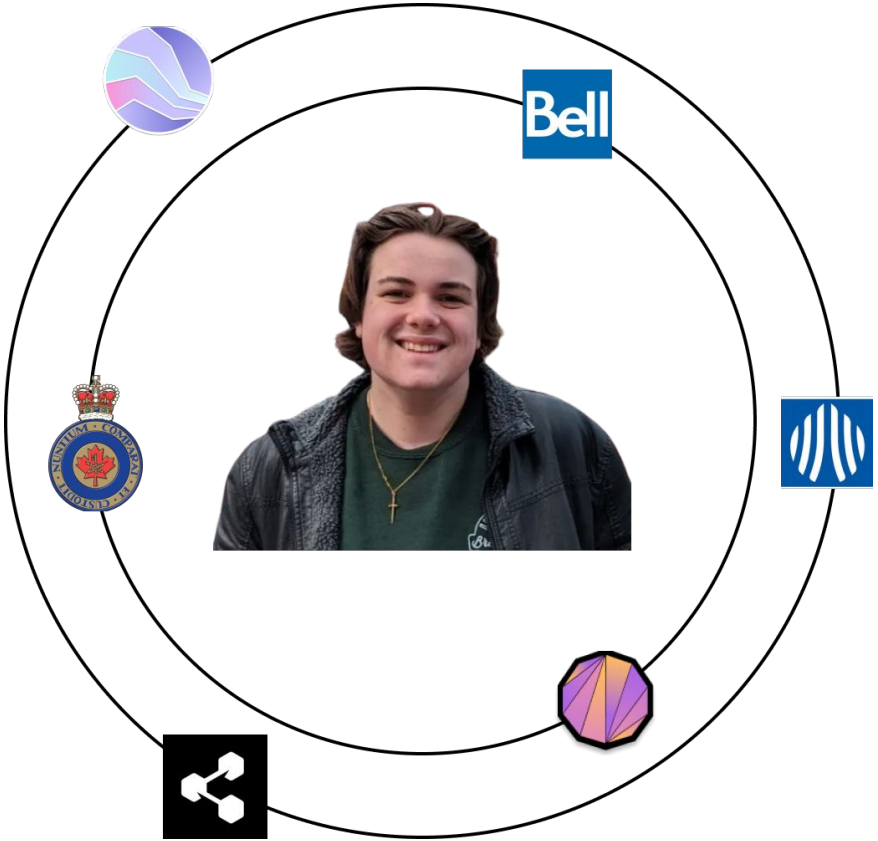
My Name is TJ

- Full-Stack Developer @ Botpress
- CS Since 2022
- Startups, Telecom, Government, Freelance, and More
- Building tech communities



My goal is not to advise you what to do, just what <u>not to do.</u>

I ’m not

o do,

The “myths” I talk about are sometimes not particularly terrible advice.

I'm n to do,

I would, however, argue it is not the best use of your time.

1. Experience & Projects

2. Networking and LinkedIn

3. YOU 'RE NOT COOKED.

Section 1: Experience

Myth 1

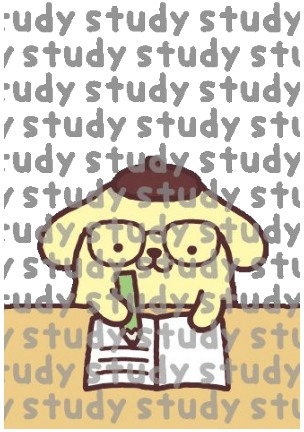
"I don't have the skills to get an internship!"

WRONG

You have more skills than you think.

Your degree means much less than you think it does.

You aren’t learning many skills directly, you’re learning how to get the skills you need.



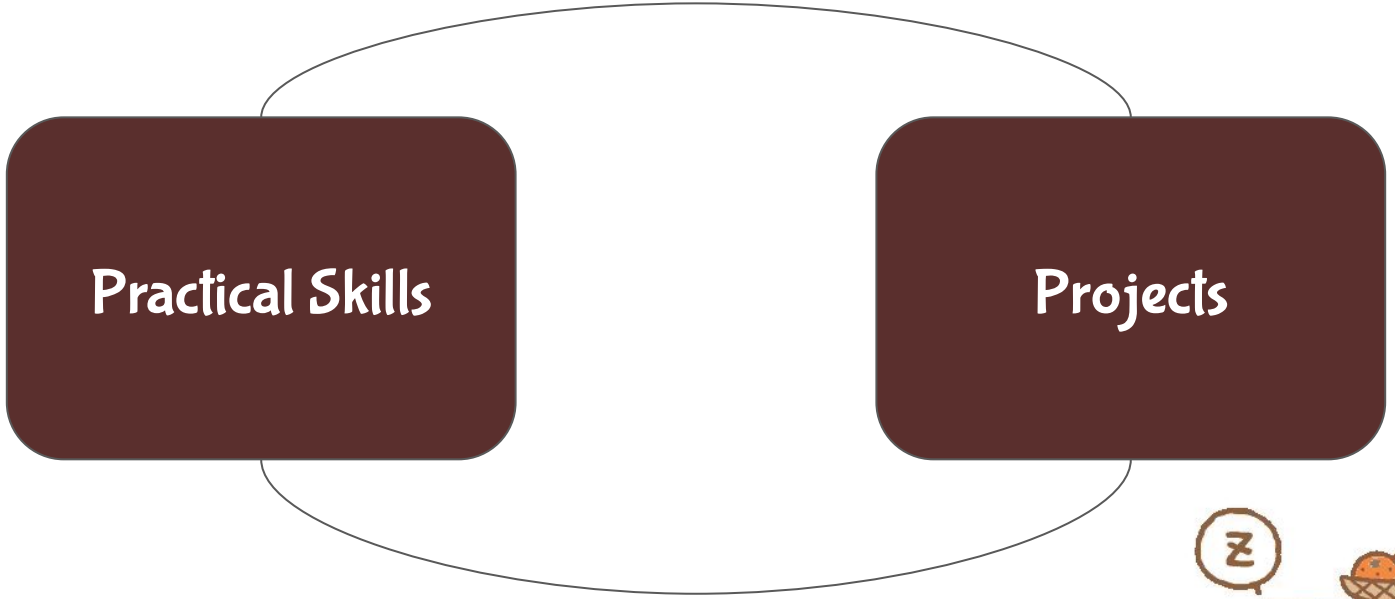
Myth 2

Just build projects to learn, duh.

Just b

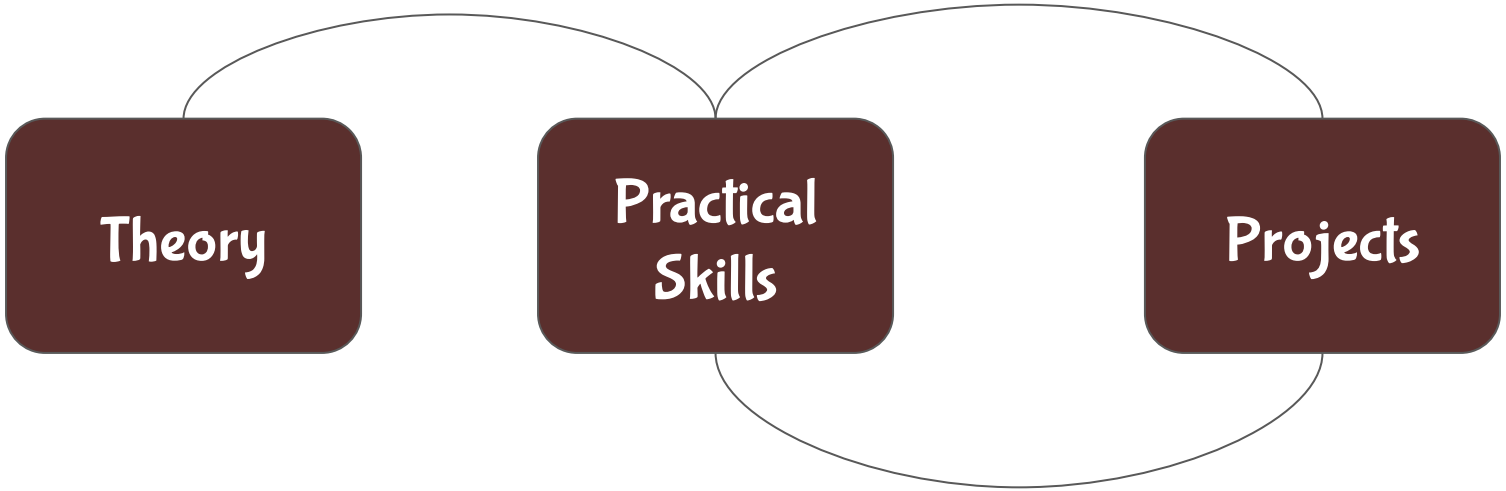
, duh.

You need skills to make “good projects”.



You need projects to get skills.

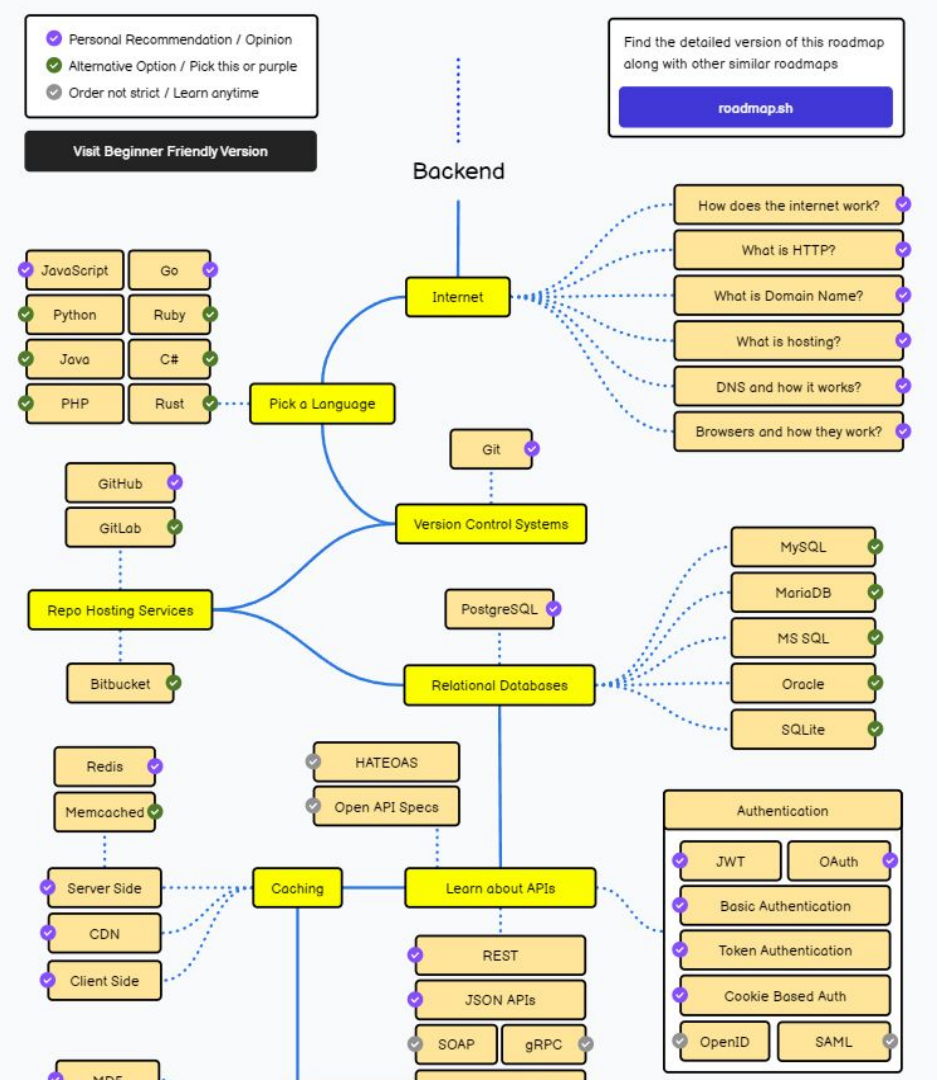
Kickstart yourself.



If you need a Roadmap, there are many available.

- You want to make {x} project with {y} skills.
- You'll need the foundations of {y}.
- Roadmaps help your loop of googling, tutorial following, project building.

roadmap.sh



Try to build a project without a tutorial.

Tutorials are good, but at some point you're just code-monkeying.

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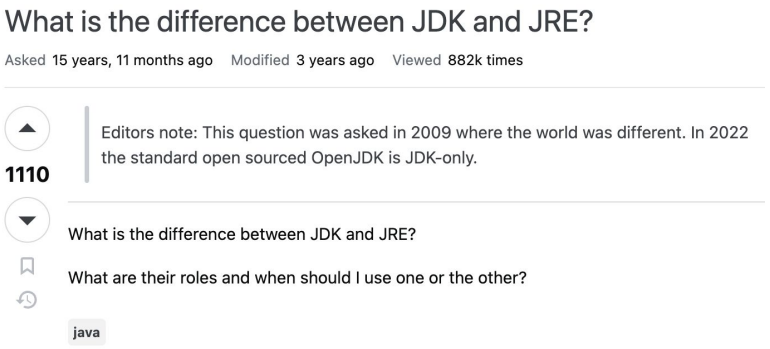


Myth 3

"All you need is a portfolio of projects to show you're ready for a full-time developer role."

Software Development is more than just code.

How to choose a project

- Make sure you're learning something new.
- Don't repeat yourself too much.
  - You don't need user accounts and authentication on every project, for example.
- Not every project needs to be a portfolio project!
  - Making small prototypes or hopping an IDE and playing around/exploring a framework or language can sometimes be the best way!

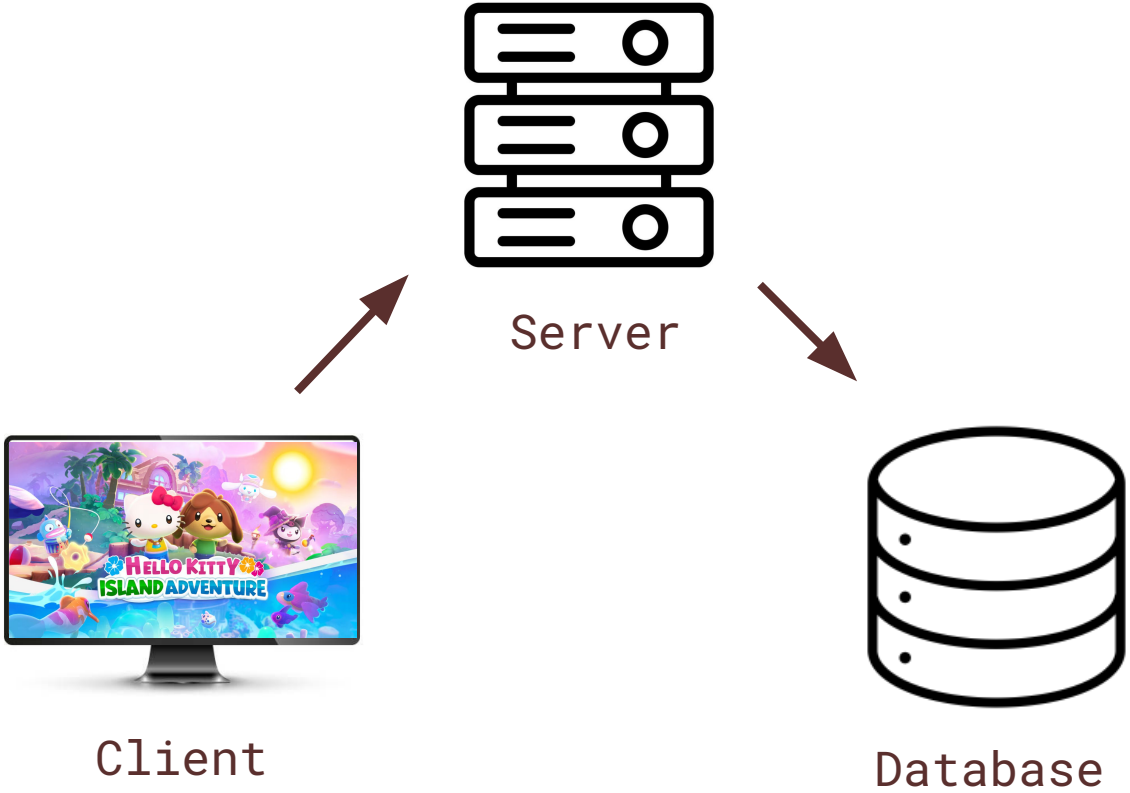
Don’t make the same project over and over again.

Recipe Tracker = To Do List App = Social Media Clone

Basic CRUD app, with database.

These don’t develop different skills.

This you?



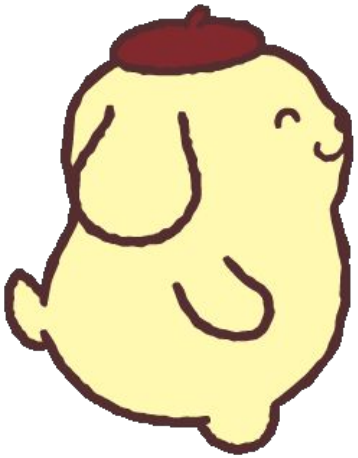
CHALLENGER APPROACHING

localhost:3000

A new foe has appeared!

Take to the sky!

Hosting your projects in the cloud is the best way to show your projects off as there’s no need for explanation.



Myth 4

"Software Development = Coder"

What your projects include:

- Front-end development
- Back-end development
- Database Management/Administration

What your projects are missing:

- CI/CD
- Cloud Services (AWS, Azure, GCP)
- Quality Assurance
- Observability
- Code Reviews
- Team Collaboration (JIRA, planning)
- Testing (where are your unit tests?)
- Monitoring + Logging
- Compliance &

- Compliance & Documentation
- Architecture/System Design
- Platform Engineering

“This is a lot. Do I really need to know all of this?”

No.

You don't need to know
ALL of this.

In fact, nobody knows
ALL of this.

Next time, just broaden your horizons just a little bit.

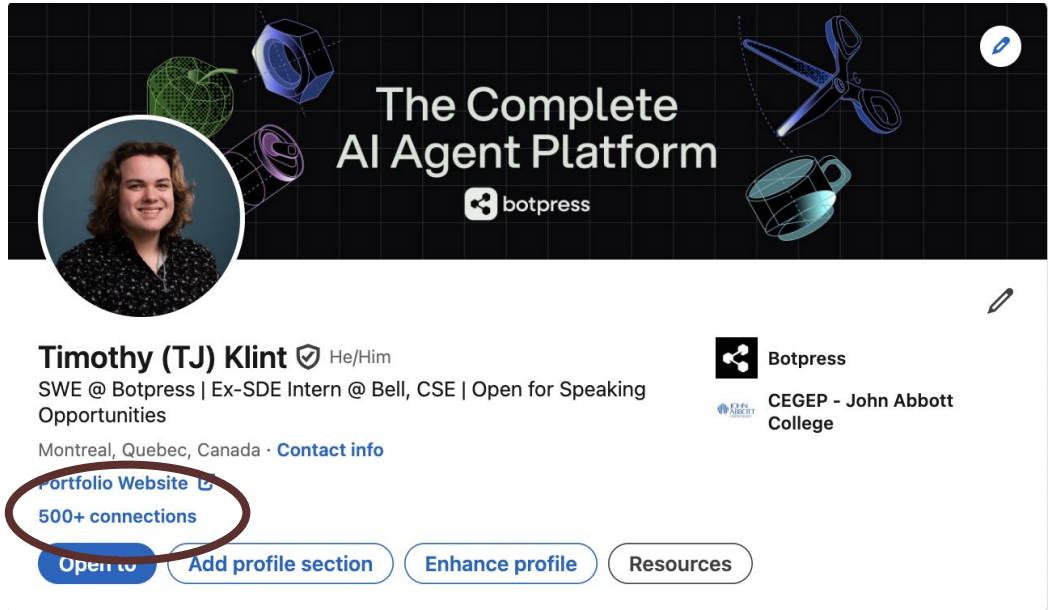
Section 2: Networking

LinkedIn®

Myth 5

"LinkedIn Connections Matter"

Good LinkedIn Connections Matter.



I regret this.

You don't want useless connections.

1,412 followers · 500+ connections

Make them useful!

Pompompuri (He/Him) · 1st

SDE Intern @ pudding factory SWE @ UCalgary

JAN 15, 2024

Pompompurin (He/Him) • 10:55 PM

Hey! It's pompom we met at CUSEC

Timothy Klint (He/Him) • 10:56 PM

Thanks for coming!

Myth 6

"A referral is the only way you're going to stand out in this market"

Does your referral really care about you?

Expectations:

"I know TypeScript AND AWS!"

"I'll refer you directly to our CEO
AND get you to final round."

Reality:

Eh...

1. They receive an email asking how they know you.
2. “They seem cool, spoke to them for 2 minutes at a hackathon”
3. The recruiter really doesn’t care.

ok...

1. HR asks do you want me to place them on your team?
2. Your referral doesn’t want to lose on other candidates.
3. They don’t do anything.

eek...

1. HR asks can you vouch for them?
2. They don’t want to put their reputation on the line, and give up.
3. This can reflect poorly on you.

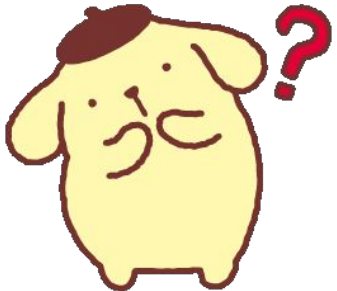
How reach out to someone

DO:

- Be direct, but kind.
- Ask a genuine question, or none at all.
- Provide an extra copy (PDF) of your resume (+ cover letter!)
- **Pro tip: Apply to the job ahead of time.**

DON'T:

- Don't ask questions you can Google.
- Don't ask "where to apply".
- Don't ask for "more info" that you can find on the application.



LinkedIn is a necessary evil.

- Recruiters will look at your LinkedIn
- This is the closest you'll get to applying face-to-face nowadays.
- Your activity "raises you" in recruiter search results
    - Every once in a while, interact with some posts, and make sure to announce your wins.

“A referral is the only way you’re going to stand out in this market”

Does your referral really care about you?

Section 3: YOU 're NOT COOKED

Myth 7

"The job market is cooked"

not really...

IN CANADA, tech jobs are projected to continue to grow over the next decade.

- Software engineers & designers: projected **+163% growth**
- Information systems managers: **+153%**
- Cybersecurity specialists: **+131%**
- Data scientists: **+126%**

IN CANADA, tech jobs are projected to continue to grow over the next decade.

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- Information systems managers: +153%
- Cybersecurity specialists: +131%
- Data scientists: +116%

"Tech industry unemployment is around ~3.3%, significantly lower than many other sectors."

Graduate Supply vs. Junior Job Openings

Graduate Supply

1. From 2010's 45,000 tech graduates, we've only gone up 30% to ~63,000.
2. Although the amount has grown, it's far less than most expect with the hype of technology.

Junior Job Openings

1. 88% of companies are hiring junior developers within the year.
2. More that 70% find it difficult to find good junior candidates.
3. Roles even requiring a degree has plummeted over the last 10 years.

You are probably confused

- If this is all true, why is it so hard for me to find a job?
- AI isn't taking over?
- In this market, why would companies want to hire juniors?

You're not cooked, the industry is.

Workflows and systems put in place for decades are needing to be updated at insane rates. Talent acquisition is one that's being screwed with hardest.

Section 3.1 (surprise!): My turn for anecdotes!

1. Elevator Pitch

2. Don't burnout.

3. Consume tech content.

4. Find nuance.

THANKS!

and enjoy the rest of CUSEC 2026!

Socials:
- linkedin.com/in/timothy-klint
- github.com/tjklint
- tjklint.com